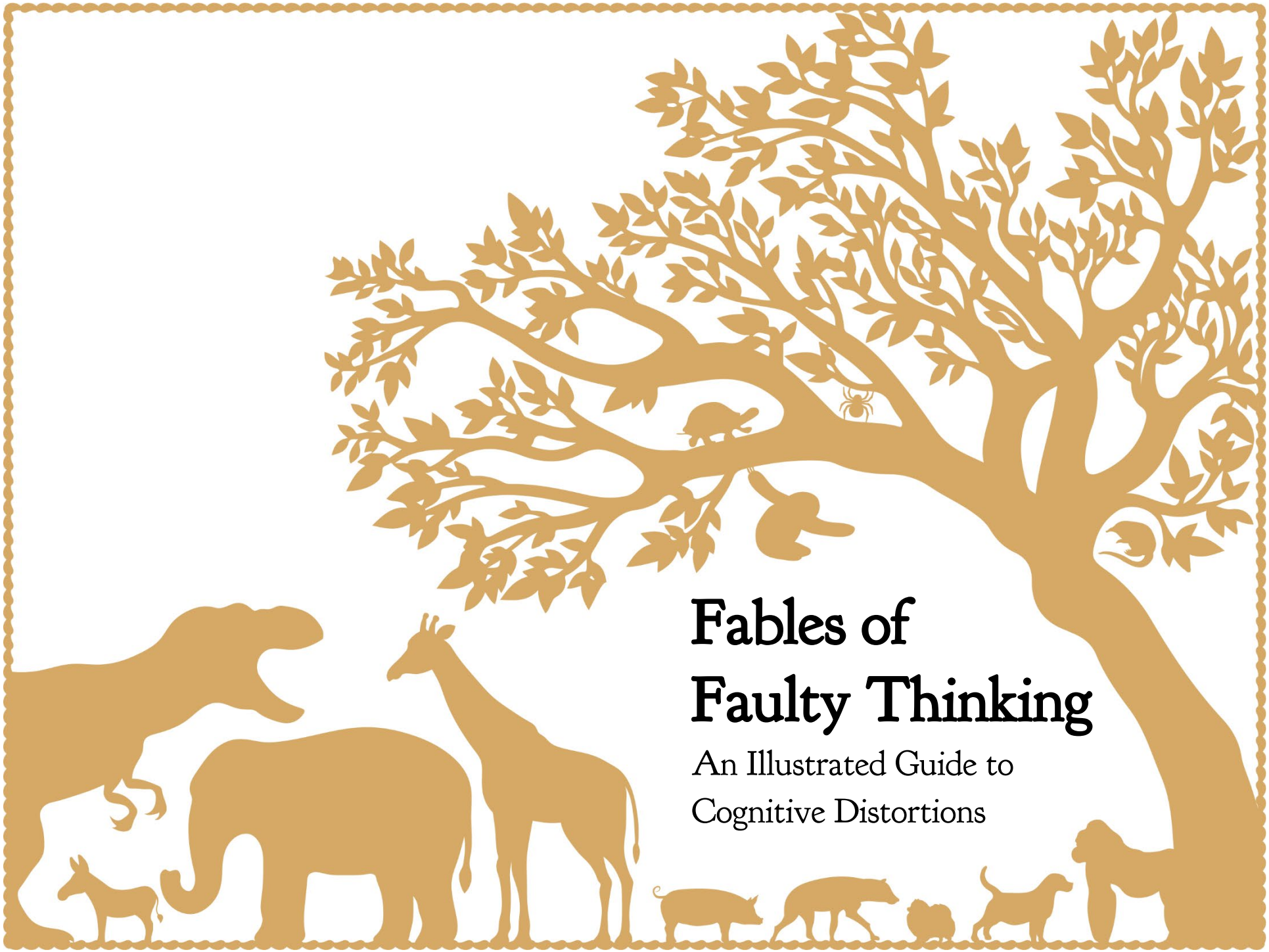

Fables of Faulty Thinking

An Illustrated Guide to Cognitive Distortions

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Introduction

Our experience as humans includes not just *what happens* to us, but also *how we think about* what happens.

For example, if we see someone frowning, we might think, “They must not like me.” This is likely to make us feel upset or angry. But we could just as easily think, “They must be having a bad day.” We are then likely to feel sorry for them and even offer to help. *The same external event can affect us in radically different ways depending on how we think about it*.

Our minds are wonderful things, but they often leap to conclusions or view situations in a negative light. Over time, this **faulty thinking** makes us feel bad about ourselves and the world around us.

Thankfully, we can correct our faulty thinking by seeing where we’ve strayed from the facts. To do this, we can ask “is there evidence this thought is true?” or “am I exaggerating?” or “are my feelings distorting things?” By adjusting our thoughts to fit the facts, we improve our mood and interactions with others.

This booklet shows animals engaging in faulty thinking in relatable human situations. Use these examples as inspiration to notice and correct your own thinking errors!

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Jumping to Conclusions

Interpreting the meaning of a situation with little to no evidence.

"There's no way I could win this race."

Mind Reading

Interpreting the thoughts and beliefs of others without adequate evidence.

"I just know they're gossiping about me again."

Disqualifying the Positive

Recognizing only the negative aspects of a situation while ignoring the positive.

"If only I could do something about the ugly birthmark on my paw."

Magnification

Exaggerating the importance of events.

"This'll take me forever – they're the size of mountains!"

Catastrophizing

Seeing only the worst possible outcomes of a situation.

"Jim's running 10 minutes late. What if something horrible happened?!"

Personalization

Believing that one is responsible for events outside of their control.

"Great – another thing I failed at!"

Emotional Reasoning

Assuming that emotions reflect
the way things really are.

"I believe I can fly!"

Magical Thinking

Believing that acts will influence
unrelated situations.

*"Step on a crack and you'll break
your mother's back"*

Minimization

Minimizing the importance of events.

"What's the fuss? Seen one shooting star, seen them all."

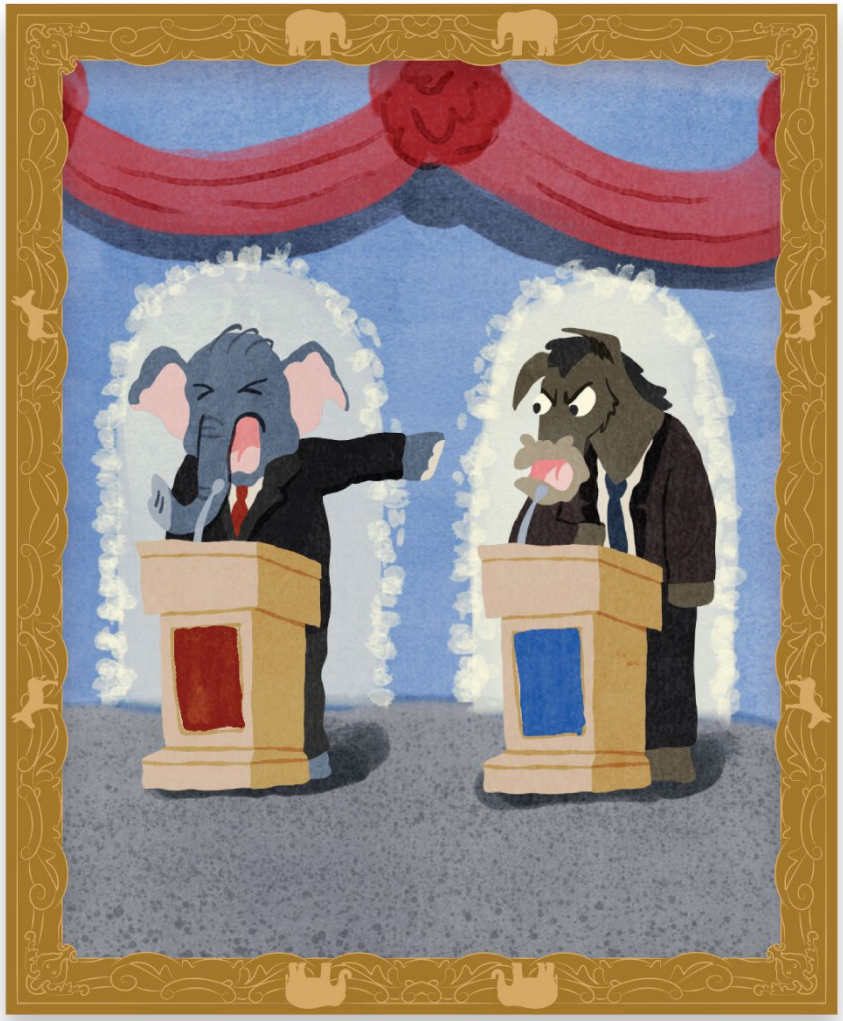
"Should" Statements

Believing that things should be a certain way.

"I should be so much further along in life!"

Overgeneralization

Making broad interpretations from
a single or few events.



"No donkey is fit to run the country!"
"All elephants lie!"

All-Or-Nothing Thinking

Thinking in absolutes such as
"always," "never," or "every."

"Worst web in the whole wide world!"